

Handheld Harmony

Also Remember...

- Opt for USB ports if you want to transfer large amounts of data between your handheld and your PC.
- From wireless modems to a digital music player, you can just add the accessory and get a new functionality added. Hand-spring's springboard connector, Palm's Expansion Card Slot, and the iPaq's Expansion Sleeves are ways to upgrade your handheld to add functionality. However, the expansion modules are generally very costly.
- Audio playback/recording offers low audio quality and is really useful only as a dictation tool.
- Customisable shortcut keys offer you quick access to certain features. Make sure they are sturdy and comfortable.
- Look for a memory expansion slot. The ability to upgrade the memory can increase the lifespan of your handheld. Openly accepted mobile memory standards like MMC and Compact Flash media are preferable to proprietary memory expansion sleeves offered by the iPaq
- Look for a PDA that fulfils your current needs, and provides just enough expandability to last you for a year or two.
- Upgradability is limited. You can't replace the processor or add more than certain types of peripheral devices.

Handheld PCs are moving towards becoming a commodity, just like mobile phones. In the past few months, a bagful of handhelds have been introduced in India, ranging from the cheap and efficient Psion and Palm m100 models to the powerful and feature-rich Pocket PC devices such as the Cassiopeia and the Compaq iPaq. However, all PDAs aren't made equal. Each represents a different mix of memory, speed, software, display, input devices, expansion slots and packaging and size, which makes some more suitable than others for a certain kind of work.

As of now, Palm OS is the market leader with good manufacturer and developer support, but Pocket PC is fast gaining popularity too.

SMART TIPS

Operating System: The main choice is between the Palm OS and Windows PocketPC. Each has its own strengths, Palm OS is simple and fast, Windows Pocket PC is slick. Other less popular options are Symbian EPOC and Agenda Computing's VR3 Linux.

RAM: A common RAM (either Static or Flash) is used for storage as well as to run applications. While 8 MB RAM is sufficient for Palm models, it would leave a Pocket PC device gasping for breath.

CPU: Palm devices use either 16 or 33 MHz DragonBall processors from Motorola. For the Pocket PC, there are three popular CPU platforms, each with its own data structures and application types. An application written for one CPU isn't necessarily compatible for another, unless re-compiled. The choices are between the Hitachi SH3, Motorola's MIPS processors and the most powerful Intel Strong ARM, which looks like becoming the default choice down the line.

ROM: The ROM stores the OS that runs on your handheld, and there is no separate BIOS/Boot loader in handhelds. Only some devices will allow you to upgrade



the information on the ROM.

Display/Touch screen: Go for a backlit display for greater convenience. Also check whether the screen is coated with a scratch-resistant skin. Colour is cool, if you can afford it.

Interface/Input devices: Most PDAs come with a touch screen and a Stylus for navigation and text input. Palm uses its proprietary Graffiti handwriting system that makes you learn the way a specific character needs

to be written. You get used to it with a few hours of experimentation. By default, PocketPC comes with a Graffiti-like handwriting recognition system, but a better option is a program called Transcriber which is available for free from Microsoft's Web site.

Batteries: Some of the low-end handhelds use regular off-the-shelf alkaline batteries. Having replaceable batteries allows you to switch batteries whenever you are running low. If your handheld comes with rechargeable batteries, it should offer at-least a day of usage time in regular conditions. Lithium ion / Lithium polymer have the best battery life and the ability to recharge at any point in time.

	Productivity only	Productivity + fun + flaunt value
You need	Basic productivity applications like address book, offline e-mail, expense tracking, scheduling and calendar, notes, etc at the lowest price possible	Productivity features and audio/video playback, as well as support for handheld gaming. It has to be slim, sleek and shiny
Look for	Long battery life, handy text input, basic synchronisation features, audible alarms and a simple backlit monochrome display	A high-powered processor and more RAM, a colour screen, audio output/input, expandable memory
Our pick	Palm m105, pSion Revo	Compaq iPaq, Cassiopeia EM500, Sony CLIE
Price range	Rs 10,000 to Rs 15,000	Rs 20,000 to Rs 30,000



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